

SUN, SEA, AND SAND The Mövenpick Resort Al Marjan Island welcomes almost 5,000 Indian tourists annually

Of course, no UAE experience is complete without enjoying luxury hospitality, and RAK has no shortage of global luxury hotels [think Mövenpick Resort Al Marjan Island, Waldorf Astoria, The Ritz-Carlton, etc.], with many more opening in the near future. The UAE's first casino—the \$3.9-billion, 1,500-key Wynn Al Marjan Island—will be inaugurated in the next couple of years, adding to the entertainment value of RAK.

Of course, if a destination is trying to vie for a larger share of the Indian wallet, weddings cannot be far behind. The tourism authorities are actively promoting RAK as a destination for weddings, and they are willing to accommodate any request from the bride or groom. Consider this: Last year, an Indian bride was hung up on being escorted by police vehicles, sirens blaring, from the airport to the hotel after she landed. And, the emirate's police chief made her wish come true.

According to the Ras Al Khaimah Tourism Development Authority, last year the emirate's wedding revenue surged by 103%, driven by the demand for destination weddings from India. "We have 12 Indian weddings scheduled for this year, with a few more in the pipeline for the first quarter of next year. Each of these weddings promises to be a grand affair," says Fabien Chesnais, GM, Mövenpick Resort Al Marjan Island, RAK.

The hotel has already hosted 10 weddings since it opened in 2022. On an average, the resort, which has a 300-metre pristine white sand beach, welcomes approximately 5,000 Indian tourists annually. "India is indeed a growing market for us. The resort has seen a steady increase in Indian guests, driven by



a growing interest in newer destinations and experiences. This demographic is attracted by the resort's amenities, scenic location, and family-friendly offerings," says Chesnais.

Whether you are a thrill seeker or a laid-back beach bum, there is plenty to do in Ras Al Khaimah.

ONE-OF-A-KIND CULTURAL JOURNEYS

Ras Al Khaimah translates to 'head of the tent,' a name that, depending on the version of the story you follow, either reflects its location at the northern tip of the country or the legend of a sheikh who hung a lantern from his tent to guide seafarers, like a lighthouse. Before oil took over in the 1950s, pearl trading was big business along the emirate's 40 miles of coastline. Divers would set out to sea on sailboats for months at a time, searching the ocean floor for oysters. They would jump in free-

style without any equipment with just a tortoiseshell clip on their nose to hold their breath. The arrival of affordable and easily accessible cultured pearls from Japan in the 1930s led to the decline of this industry. You can learn all about it at the Suwaidi Pearl Farm, the first and only one in the Gulf.

The farm provides tours, offering insights into ancient techniques and stories of the region's pearl divers. It includes a trip on a traditional pearling boat. But the best part? Trying your luck to see if you find a pearl inside an oyster. I did!

MOUNTAIN ADVENTURES

RAK is home to the highest peak in the UAE, meaning there are plenty of mountain activities to enjoy, especially for thrill seekers. The chief among them is Jais Flight, which has been recognised as the world's longest zip line by the Guinness